Paris massacre burst onto Japan's television screens, a reminder of the type of danger that Japan does not face.

Unlike the West, consumed by the threat of terrorism for half a generation, Japan is a modernized and liberal society not directly at risk from the Islamic State, al-Qaeda, and homegrown Islamist radicals. Like any nation, it offers a plethora of soft targets, but the reality is that Japan is in comparatively little danger. Its people live in a reality entirely different from that of the West, spared from a seemingly endless fight against an implacable enemy who now lives among them. This is due in part to the fact that Japan prioritizes order over openness and stability over opportunity. It is also undoubtedly due to the fact that, until now, its regional environment has been largely benign and because of the security guarantees offered it since 1952 by the United States.

That benign environment has been growing more threatening since the mid-1990s, however, thanks to China's rapid military modernization program and assertive behavior, as well as North Korea's continuing nuclear and ballistic missile program. That these threats emerged right at the beginning of Japan's economic malaise added another level of worry for the public and policy makers. Despite a deepening of the alliance with the United States, including two revisions to the guidelines of the alliance that increased levels of cooperation between Tokyo and Washington, doubts continue to persist in Japan over the ultimate credibility of American guarantees for their security, given the scope of the challenges and the focus of US policy makers on the Middle East and other parts of the globe.

Polls show that Japanese have become increasingly concerned over the threats posed by North Korea and China in recent years. A Pew poll of September 2016 found that 86 percent of Japanese held unfavorable views of China, with 71 percent believing the Chinese were violent, a 21 percent increase from 2006.[18] Interestingly, fully 74 percent of Chinese interviewed in the same poll believed Japanese were violent, despite 70 years of a pacifist society and constitution and essentially no Japanese military presence abroad, underscoring the trust deficit in